

**Dashing hussar**
The hussars cultivated an image of reckless courage and death-defying boldness in action, always trying to outdo the rest of the French cavalry in feats of horsemanship.

moment in a battle. They were used in mass charges, a role that required discipline and horsemanship rather than dash and initiative.

The light cavalry, by contrast, were generally distributed among Napoleon's army corps – large formations in which they operated in collaboration with infantry and artillery. They consisted initially of hussars and chasseurs; these were later joined by increasing numbers of lancers. Hussars saw themselves as the most dashing of cavalry. Their attractiveness to women was legendary – they were said to be "hated by husbands and loved by wives". The hussars thought themselves far superior to the chasseurs, whose uniforms were cheaper and less splendid, and rivalry between the two was intense. Chasseurs carried carbines and on occasion fought on foot. Otherwise, the function of hussars and chasseurs was broadly identical. They acted as scouts, carrying out reconnaissance patrols and harassing raids, and screening the movements of the army from the enemy. Activities of this kind involved small groups operating independently and gave plenty of chance to show initiative. On the battlefield light cavalry would charge with their sabres held low to run infantrymen through. They were noted for their spirit of attack and speed in pursuit of a defeated enemy.

## LANCERS AND DRAGOONS

One of the notable changes in military technology that took place during the Napoleonic Wars was the widespread use of lances as a light cavalry weapon. During the 18th century lancers were generally regarded as an exotic, marginal element in European warfare. The most famous lancers in Europe were the Polish cavalry known as Uhlans, who were renowned for their wild behaviour and independent fighting spirit.




**Cuirassier uniform**
The cuirassier's tunic was less spectacular than those worn by the light cavalry, but it was usually covered by his armour – cuirass and back plate. He made up for this with his magnificent plumed helmet.

# HEAVY CAVALRY TACTICS

Napoleon's conception of the cuirassiers was as a force capable of delivering a mass cavalry charge of overwhelming power at a key point on the battlefield, if possible precipitating a general collapse of the enemy forces. In theory, there would be a preliminary artillery bombardment to weaken the enemy before the charge was launched, gradually accelerating from its start to the moment of encounter.

### THEORY AND PRACTICE

Beginning at a trot, the cuirassiers were supposed to shift up to a canter and then, some 150m (500ft) from the enemy, break into a gallop, reaching full tilt over the last 50m (150ft). In practice, though, French commanders preferred to use the cuirassiers in a close formation that militated against such a headlong charge. They ordered the heavy cavalry to advance in a massive, tightly packed column, with men riding boot to boot. The difficulty of maintaining formation in the massed column made it virtually impossible to progress at any great speed, and of course deprived the individual cavalryman of any chance to use his initiative. But it did create a body moving with almost unstoppable momentum, capable of breaking enemy cavalry formations apart and beating down loosely organized infantry with hoof and sabre. The cuirassiers, however, had no adequate tactics for penetrating infantry squares that held firm with bayonets fixed, as was demonstrated at the battle of Waterloo. When they charged in dense formation they were also particularly vulnerable to well-directed artillery fire.